

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Problem-Solving and Data Analysis	Ratios, rates, proportional relationships, and units	Hard

Question

Objects R and S each travel at a constant speed. The speed of object R is half the speed of object S. Object R travels a distance of $4x$ inches in y seconds. Which expression represents the time, in seconds, it takes object S to travel a distance of $24x$ inches?

Answer

- A. $12y$
- B. $3y$
- C. $16y$
- D. $6y$

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is correct. It's given that object R travels a distance of $4x$ inches in y seconds. This speed can be written as $\frac{4x \text{ inches}}{y \text{ seconds}}$. It's given that the speed of object R is half the speed of object S. It follows that the speed of object S is twice the speed of object R, which is $2\left(\frac{4x \text{ inches}}{y \text{ seconds}}\right)$, or $\frac{8x \text{ inches}}{y \text{ seconds}}$. Let n represent the time, in seconds, it takes object S to travel a distance of $24x$ inches. The value of n can be found by solving the equation $\frac{8x \text{ inches}}{y \text{ seconds}} = \frac{24x \text{ inches}}{n \text{ seconds}}$, which can be written as $\frac{8x}{y} = \frac{24x}{n}$. Multiplying each side of this equation by ny yields $8xn = 24xy$. Dividing each side of this equation by $8x$ yields $n = 3y$. Therefore, the expression $3y$ represents the time, in seconds, it takes object S to travel a distance of $24x$ inches.

Choice A is incorrect. This expression represents the time, in seconds, it would take object S to travel a distance of $24x$ inches if the speed of object R were twice, not half, the speed of object S.

Choice C is incorrect. This expression represents the time, in seconds, it takes object S to travel a distance of $128x$ inches, not $24x$ inches.

Choice D is incorrect. This expression represents the time, in seconds, it takes object R, not object S, to travel a distance of $24x$ inches.